Assay: Business Proposal

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Old-world value. A quant in your pocket.

Executive summary

When everybody is mining for gold, sell the shovel. Assay sells the tools that test whether an investment idea is gold, not the gold itself. It is a self-service investing app that screens US shares on Benjamin Graham's value rules, shows every trade behind its conclusions and lets members test their own strategies against the S&P 500.

- **The model:** low-cost subscriptions from $1 to $15 a month, with about 90% of members expected on a $4 tier. Assay never holds money or executes trades; members buy on a platform of their choice, starting with EasyEquities' USD wallet. The aim is a partnership with EasyEquities, which gains clients who move beyond index funds, and its Australian clients are the first expansion.
- **Two model lines, one backbone:** *Newtonian* models apply Graham's classical rules; *Einsteinian* models are built with machine learning. Both are tested by the same backtesting engine against the same benchmark.
- **The promise:** at least the market's return, while knowing what you own and without having to decide what to buy, how much, or when to sell. The house models aim for about 2% a year above the S&P 500 total-return index, with not doing worse as the minimum.
- **The difference:** transparent, quant-style reports that show the good picks beside the bad, and an honest answer to the question every part-time trader has: was my backtest luck?
- **The ambition:** a side project that grows organically, with about $50,000 a year in profit as success. That takes roughly 1,500 to 2,000 paying members.
- **Where it stands:** the research engine exists and runs on S&P 500 data. A private beta with a few invited testers comes next, once the strategy has proven itself out-of-sample.

The problem and the opportunity

Most retail investors stop at index funds because picking shares feels like guessing. They do not know which companies to choose, how much to put in each, or when to sell. Assay answers all three with

rules they can read.

- **South African retail investors** hold mostly index funds and ETFs. Platforms such as EasyEquities give them cheap access to US shares in fractions, but no guidance on which shares to buy.
- **Part-time traders** write strategies, sometimes with an AI chat assistant, but cannot tell whether a good backtest was skill or luck. They lack the quant background to test it properly, and no affordable tool does it for them.
- **The target member** sits between the index investor and the day trader: willing to take more risk than the S&P 500, but wanting to look at the portfolio about once a year.

The opportunity is the gap between expensive professional research and free tips with no proof. Graham's rules are simple, published and testable, so the screening costs almost nothing to run. What has been missing is honest proof and a clear report, delivered cheaply and at scale.

Services

Assay offers five services, built in this order: house picks first, the platform last.

1. **House picks, in two model lines.** Each quarter, or as often as new filings arrive, the house models publish their picks with the reasons behind them and their record against the S&P 500.
    - **Newtonian: Graham's rules.** Classical mechanics for investing: simple, published tests that sort companies into pass and fail buckets. Every pick can be explained in a sentence.
    - **Einsteinian: machine-learning models.** Where Graham's buckets break into the AI generation: models trained on the same point-in-time data find patterns the fixed rules cannot. Each pick shows which inputs drove it.
    - **One backbone.** Both lines run through the same backtesting engine, the same hold-out period and the same benchmark, so a member compares them like for like.
2. **Interactive analysis.** Members adjust the settings themselves (number of picks, how often the screen recalibrates, risk) and see what the model would have chosen and earned. Every setting is scored on a hold-out period it was not tuned on, so the history cannot be cherry-picked. This is the "quant in your pocket".
3. **Testing platform for mavericks.** A member brings a riskier strategy, in shares or another market such as Bitcoin, and Midas backtests it, builds stress scenarios and reports whether it is viable or just lucky.
4. **Bring your own Claude.** Members connect their own Claude subscription to a restricted Midas server. It exposes the rules, documents and backtest engine, but never the code. Members develop strategies inside a controlled structure, and the chat costs Assay nothing.
5. **Creator platform.** Members publish their tested strategies and market views. Others follow, like and subscribe, and creators earn a commission when their models are used. Every published strategy is scored by the same engine, on the same hold-out.

Tier	Price a month	What the member gets
Standard	free to $1	About 3 house picks, a few adjustable settings
Plus	about $4 (expected for 90% of members)	More picks, more risk settings, an investment plan, the full report
Premium	up to $15	Tracks the member's own holdings, full portfolio report, the testing platform

Prices are ballpark and will be set once there are users. Assay never holds money or executes trades: members buy on their own platform and tell Assay what they bought.

Competition

Each part of Assay exists somewhere, but no competitor combines open Graham rules, member-tuned strategies scored out-of-sample, and a full written report. Only eToro among the direct competitors is listed; the rest are private.

Competitor	What it offers	Overlap with Assay	Listed
InvestingPro, ProPicks AI	AI strategies updated monthly, the same for every subscriber	Picks and tiers; not personalised, no chat	No
Validea	Model portfolios on gurus' rules, including Graham	Closest on method; no personalisation	No
GuruFocus, Old School Value	Graham Number and guru screens	Graham metrics as a tool for enthusiasts	No
Magnifi	Conversational AI assistant with a brokerage	Chat-steered investing; no stated method	No
Danelfin	AI score from 1 to 10 per stock	Ranked picks; a black box	No
Sterling Stock Picker, StockPick AI	Risk questionnaire, then picks	Almost the Standard tier	No
Simply Wall St, Seeking Alpha	Portfolio tracking, visual reports, quant ratings	The Premium tier	No
Composer	Build, backtest and automate rule strategies	Testing for technical users	No
eToro, TradingView	Copy trading and paid creators; published scripts and ideas	The creator platform	eToro yes (Nasdaq: ETOR)

Listed neighbours that are not direct competitors: Robinhood (HOOD), Interactive Brokers (IBKR), Charles Schwab (SCHW), Morningstar (MORN), Value Line (VALU), and the data firms S&P Global, MSCI, Moody's and FactSet.

What sets Assay apart

Assay's edge is honesty that can be checked: every result is shown with the trades behind it, scored the same way for everyone, against the S&P 500.

- **Transparent quant reports.** Each report shows every trade made to reach its conclusion, the bad picks beside the good, and which rules each company passed. Competitors show a score or a dashboard; Assay hands over the working.
- **Out-of-sample scoring.** Fundamentals are taken as they were first filed with the SEC, and every strategy is judged on a period it was never tuned on. The benchmark is always the S&P 500 total-return index.
- **"Was it luck?" tests.** Each strategy is compared with many random strategies of the same kind, and its risk-adjusted return is corrected for the number of variants tried.
- **Rules you can read.** Graham's tests are published and simple. A member can see why a company passed, not just that an AI liked it.
- **Safer in a bubble's correction.** The rules exclude overvalued shares by design, so a correction of an AI bubble should hurt the house models less than the index. The cost is trailing the index while a bubble inflates; the reports show both phases.
- **Speed and cost.** Large research firms still run on spreadsheets and slow approval processes. An automated report pipeline delivers the same kind of report in minutes, at a fraction of the cost.
- **A brand unlike the rest.** Competitors look like Bloomberg terminals or crypto apps. Assay looks like a fine mechanical watch: precise, certain, and quietly modern.

About the founder

Jan-Albert Viljoen brings the two worlds Assay joins: the rigour of theoretical physics and the stability that enterprise finance demands.

- **Physics.** A South African theoretical astrophysicist by training, with a PhD in cosmology specialising in general relativity. The Einsteinian model line takes its name from that background.
- **Fintech.** After his doctorate he moved into fintech, training credit-risk and other risk models with machine learning.
- **Big Four.** He is a Financial Risk Manager in the quantitative department of a Big Four firm, where most of his work brings fintech practice to large banks: upgrading their software infrastructure where architecture changes slowly.
- **Now.** He has built an enterprise-grade development environment in which an MCP server helps extend the code base at speed, while the financial logic follows industry standards and the infrastructure stays reliable and auditable.

Assay is built the same way: old-world stability, new-world innovation.

Market and financial projection

About 1,500 to 2,000 paying members deliver the $50,000 a year that counts as success, and the market already pays this price at scale. Robinhood Gold earned $50 million in the fourth quarter of 2025 from 4.2 million subscribers: about $4 a subscriber a month, Assay's expected main tier.

Unit economics at $4 a month. A member pays $48 a year. App stores take 15% from small developers, and the chat and data cost an assumed $8 a year, leaving about $33 per member. With members bringing their own Claude, the chat cost largely falls away.

Paying members	Revenue a year	Profit a year (about $33 each)
500	$24,000	$16,500
1,500	$72,000	$49,500
2,000	$96,000	$66,000
10,000	$480,000	$330,000

Fixed costs (a price-data licence, hosting) come off these figures. **Conversion sets the reach needed:** freemium apps convert a median 2.2% of downloads to paying members (RevenueCat, 2025), so 1,500 to 2,000 payers need about 75,000 to 100,000 sign-ups.

What listed neighbours earn (latest fiscal year, from results releases):

Company	Revenue	Net income	Net margin
Robinhood (2025)	$4.5 bn	$1.9 bn	about 42%
FactSet (FY Sep 2024 to Aug 2025)	$2.32 bn	$597 m	about 26%
eToro (2025)	$868 m (net contribution)	$216 m	about 25%
Morningstar (2025)	$2.4 bn	$374 m	about 16%
Value Line (FY May 2025 to Apr 2026)	$33.4 m (publishing)	$21.6 m, mostly investment income	operating about 12%

Two lessons follow. Subscription research at scale nets 16% to 26% after paying large staff, so a lean operation can do better early. And Value Line, the closest old-school value publisher, is shrinking: publishing revenue fell 4.7% in its last year. Old-world value sold the old way does not grow; the fintech half of Assay has to carry it.

Brand and positioning

Assay is old school colliding with fintech: Graham's almost forgotten principles, steered by an AI assistant, sold at small prices with the look of wealth.

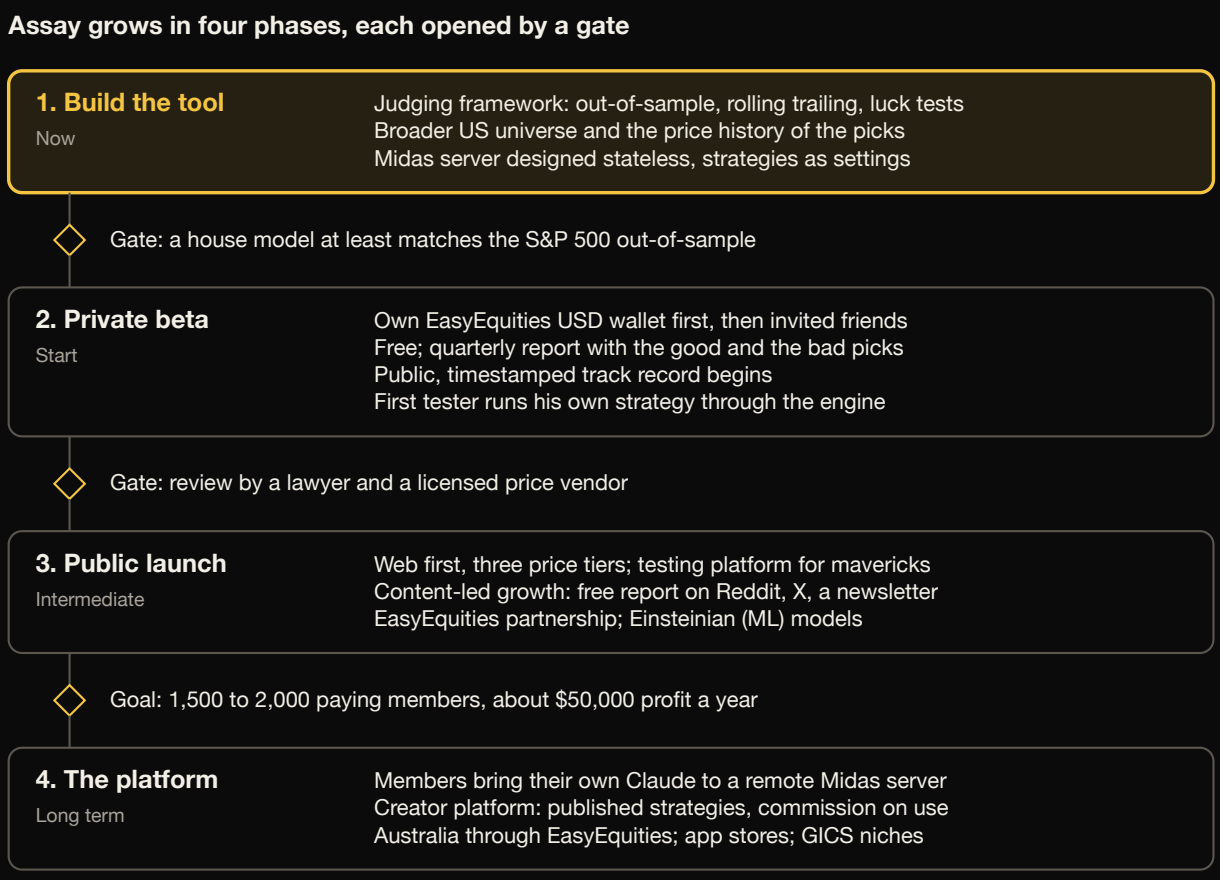
- **The name.** To assay is to test whether gold is genuine. The word comes from Old French *assai*, a form of *essai* ("trial"), from Late Latin *exagium* ("a weighing"), and shares its root with *essay*:

fitting for an app that weighs companies and writes a report on them. Assay offices still stamp the hallmark that certifies a precious metal; Assay's reports are meant to carry the same weight.

- **Midas, the assistant.** The chatbot is Midas: the king with the golden touch who has learned to be careful with it. Exact, helpful, and strict about what turns to gold.
- **The look: fine watchmaking.** In a world of smartwatches, a mechanical watch from a maison such as Patek Philippe still stands for precision and certainty that last generations. Assay is that watch with modern flair, like a fine mechanical watch that can also pay contactlessly: old engineering in the movement, new technology where it serves the wearer. The cues are the dial, the hand-finished movement behind a glass caseback, and the chronometer certificate that proves its accuracy, as Assay's hold-out tests prove a strategy. The logo already sets Midas's crowned face inside a dial.
- **Long-term value.** Patek Philippe's line, that you never own one but only look after it for the next generation, is the spirit of value investing. Assay borrows the idea, not the words or the marks.
- **A second inspiration.** The hand-built Dutch supercars of Spyker, whose aviation history shows in their turned-aluminium dashboards and exposed gear linkage, add a sense of craft and adventure.
- **A motto.** Seneca's *Ignis aurum probat*: fire tests gold. It names what the platform does, testing every strategy under stress before it is trusted.
- **The counterpoint to crypto.** Everyone chases quick wealth in assets with no measurable value. Assay keeps the spirit of adventure, hunting for underdogs that can become giants, but bases every choice on value that can be measured. It is counting cards, not a lottery.
- **The line:** *Old-world value. A quant in your pocket.*

Route to market and timeline

Assay grows at the pace of a hobby beside a day job: each phase opens only when the gate before it is passed, not on a fixed date.



Roadmap · 4 phases, 3 gates · phases are not to scale

The tool comes first, because the product is the proof. Content comes before the app: the free quarterly report and its public track record build the audience, and no paid advertising is planned early, because clicks on finance keywords are expensive.

Partnership with EasyEquities. The aim, once the beta has a track record, is a partnership with EasyEquities. Assay gives its clients a reason to move beyond index funds into individual shares, which grows EasyEquities' portfolio base; EasyEquities gives Assay its members and, as a licensed provider, a possible answer to the licensing question. EasyEquities also serves clients in Australia, which makes Australia the natural first expansion beyond South Africa.

Risks and open questions

The largest risk is regulatory: picks tailored to one person count as investment advice in most countries, whatever the disclaimer says. Each question below is settled before the public launch.

Risk	Why it matters	Response
Advice or tool	Personal recommendations need a licence (FAIS in South Africa, comparable rules in the US, EU and UK). Gamified framing draws regulators' attention.	Members set their own settings and the app shows what passes: a tool, not advice. A securities lawyer reviews before launch. Licensing in Mauritius (FSC) or Abu Dhabi (ADGM) is under consideration, but may not cover South African members.
Platform liability	Creators paid for strategies others follow may be giving advice themselves. US Section 230 does not cover securities law; South Africa's safe harbour is conditional.	Terms of use and the licence cover creators; house models are called "house" or "Midas" models, never "accredited".
Data licensing	Yahoo price data may not be redistributed in a product, free or paid. Using the S&P 500 name may need a licence.	SEC EDGAR for fundamentals; a licensed price vendor before launch.
Overfitting	Members tuning settings until the history looks good fit the past, not the future. Among thousands of creator strategies, the best are mostly lucky.	Hold-out scoring for every setting; rankings and creator pay based on results after publication.
Unproven edge	No house model has yet beaten the S&P 500 out-of-sample.	Nothing is marketed until it has; the public track record starts with the beta.
Value lags in bubbles	Value strategies trailed badly in 1998 to 2000 and 2019 to 2021.	Reports show trailing periods openly; the promise is "not worse" over time, not every year.

The private beta is free and limited to invited testers, which keeps it informal; the questions above apply once anyone pays or the app opens to the public.

Two further points:

- **Einsteinian models overfit more easily.** Machine-learning models have many more settings than Graham's rules, so they find patterns in the past that do not repeat. They face the same gate as the Newtonian models, a hold-out period they were never trained on, and they are not published until they pass it.
- **Australia has its own rules.** Advice there needs an Australian Financial Services Licence from ASIC; general advice, not tailored to one person, is lighter but still regulated. A partnership with a licensed platform is the likely route.